



‘A scorched country’



SAJJAD SAFARI/AP

Rescue workers search for survivors Friday in southern Tehran. Bombs are shaking the city day and night, leaving residents in a state of shock.

Economy was shakier than thought before outset of war in Middle East

Benchmarks, which predate offensive against Iran, point to weaker growth, pesky inflation

BY ANDREW ACKERMAN

The U.S. economy was in worse shape in the weeks before the United States and Israel launched strikes against Iran than earlier government estimates had suggested, according to two closely watched economic benchmarks released Friday, painting a picture of slowing

growth and stubborn inflation.

The Commerce Department downwardly revised its estimate of economic growth in the fourth quarter of last year, saying that gross domestic product expanded at just 0.7 percent annual rate in the final three months of 2025, much smaller than the 1.4 percent pace the department had reported in an “advance” estimate last month.

A separate Commerce Department report showed that underlying inflation remained stubbornly elevated in January. The Federal Reserve’s preferred inflation gauge, the Personal Consumption Expenditures price index, rose

SEE ECONOMY ON A11

Full inquiry launched into school strike that Trump blamed on Iran

The move appears to tacitly acknowledge growing body of evidence of U.S. responsibility

BY DAN LAMOTHE AND ALEX HORTON

Defense Secretary Pete Hegseth said Friday that the U.S. military has opened a comprehensive investigation into last month’s deadly strike on an elementary school in Iran, in what appeared to be a tacit acknowledgment of the United

States’ responsibility for the incident and a shift to examining how it occurred.

Hegseth, speaking at a Pentagon news conference, did not explicitly acknowledge the United States was at fault for the Feb. 28 incident — which left at least 175 dead, mostly children, according to Iranian officials — but he said that “the truth matters.”

His comments coincide with a growing body of evidence suggesting the U.S. military carried out the strike in Minab, a city in southern Iran. The Pentagon does not typically conduct such investigations of another country’s military operations.

The secretary spoke as the Pentagon

SEE IRAN ON A10

Six killed in crash of Air Force refueler

OPERATING IN IRAQ IN SUPPORT OF IRAN WAR

An apparent midair accident; other aircraft landed safely

BY TARA COPP, ALEX HORTON AND EVAN HILL

All six service members aboard a U.S. Air Force refueling aircraft that crashed in Iraq while supporting operations in Iran are dead, military officials said Friday.

The KC-135 refueling aircraft was lost while flying over friendly airspace Thursday in western Iraq, U.S. Central Command said, in an apparent midair accident with another aircraft.

Centcom’s announcement brought the death toll of the crash from four to six, after earlier saying that rescue efforts were underway for the last two crew members. “The circumstances of the incident are under investigation,” the Centcom statement said, adding that the identities of the deceased personnel would be withheld for 24 hours while next of kin were notified.

The incident occurred as U.S. forces have intensified inland strikes on the launch and storage sites that Iran uses for its arsenal of missiles and drones. Speaking alongside Defense Secretary Pete Hegseth at the Pentagon on Friday morning, the Joint Chiefs chairman, Gen. Dan Caine, said that the KC-135 crash happened during a combat mission but “was not the result of hostile or friendly fire.”

“Please keep these brave airmen, their families, friends and units in your thoughts in the coming hours and days,” Caine said, reading from his prepared remarks. “Those are very, very, very tough days when that knock comes on the door.”

Hegseth acknowledged the loss of life approximately 10 minutes into his opening statement, after making disparaging remarks about the news media. “War is hell,” he said. “War is chaos. And as we saw yesterday with the tragic crash of our KC-135 tanker, bad things can happen.” Hegseth called the tanker crew “American heroes.”

SEE CRASH ON A11

Cuba confirms secret meetings with U.S. amid Trump’s threats

President has warned that the island nation is next in line after Venezuela, Iran

BY KAREN DEYOUNG, SAMANTHA SCHMIDT AND ADAM TAYLOR

Amid crippling U.S. sanctions, an oil blockade and threats of a takeover, Cuban President Miguel Díaz-Canel on Friday said his government has held direct talks with the United States “aimed at finding solutions through dialogue to the bilateral differences between the two nations.”

The acknowledgment came in a publicly broadcast speech during a meeting in Havana of the top levels of the government and Cuban Communist Party. It confirmed widespread reports of recent secret meetings between senior Trump administration officials and Cubans close to Raúl Castro, the still-influential former president and party head.

SEE CUBA ON A12



ROBERT F. BUKATY/AP

Flocking together

Snow geese take off last week from the 6,300-acre Middle Creek property in Kleinfeltersville, Pennsylvania, to resume their migration to the Arctic. The birds have been arriving in growing numbers here since the late 1990s.

For a few short weeks they are the main attraction, drawing about 150,000 visitors annually. Story, A5

Grenell leaves Kennedy Center after tumultuous stint as president

Ticket sales plummeted during his tenure as he oversaw sweeping leadership changes

BY JANAY KINGSBERRY AND KELSEY ABLES

Richard Grenell, the Trump ally installed to lead the John F. Kennedy Center for the Performing Arts, is leaving the post after just over a year at the helm of the cultural institution — ending a turbulent tenure marked by staff departures, artist cancellations and plummeting ticket sales.

President Donald Trump on Friday confirmed the leadership change in a Truth Social post, announcing that Matt Floca, the center’s vice president of facilities operations, will succeed Grenell pending board approval. Trump, who plans to close the center in July for a two-year reconstruction project, also posted renderings of the planned renovation, though exterior changes visible

SEE GRENELL ON A4

IN THE NEWS

Trump’s ‘favorite Mormon’ Chris Klomp, a political unknown a year ago, is now steering the \$2.6 trillion HHS. The president is relying on him to deliver health care wins. A6

Heavy snow, high winds A powerful storm is about to blast the northern Plains, Midwest and Great Lakes into southeastern Canada. A4

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Republicans in Florida say they may not be able to deliver a hoped-for redistricting bonanza. A3

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A voter guide to the April 21 referendum in Virginia that could add four Democratic seats to the state’s congressional delegation. B12
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